

Neighbours **PAKISTAN**

operations in the region has already crossed 1.5 million. No wonder then that the UN High Commission for Refugees (UNHCR) is calling it the largest internal displacement in the world in 15 years, after the Rwanda genocide.

This brewing humanitarian crisis only adds another worrying element to the existential threat that Pakistan faces from militant extremists, who have been encouraged to expand their influence because of the Government's slowness to respond. In the past two weeks, the Pakistan Army has determinedly taken on Taliban militants in their strongholds. The military operation in Swat—where the provincial government had signed a "peace accord" with Islamist militants only three months ago—followed on the heels of a smaller operation in Buner and Dir where militants had begun to infiltrate from Swat. Most of the areas of Buner and Lower Dir have been cleared of the Taliban although pockets do remain where the army is facing stiff resistance. In Swat, as troop buildup continues for the inevitable ground assault, the army is currently shelling the militants from the air using helicopter gunships, tanks and mortar launchers. On May 12, special unit commandos were air-dropped into Peochar, a militant stronghold, who then helped gather intelligence in the targeting of laser-guided bombs fired from F-16 jets. In Mingora city, however, the army believes militants are hunkering down for the ground assault and residents relate tales of Taliban taking over houses. The city is completely cut off from the rest of Pakistan, with no electricity, gas or operational telephones.

Despite their almost total control over Swat, it was the Taliban infiltration in Buner and Dir, in fact, that had finally set alarm bells ringing around the world. The usual refrain, that the Taliban "are now only 60 miles from Islamabad", while technically incorrect and wildly sensational in its implication, did help to focus a dithering Government's attention on the issue of "Talibanisation" that most of Pakistan had been obsessed with



since the February 16 accords. Most independent analysts had immediately raised the red flag over the Swat accords, signed between the secular Awami National Party-led Government of the North-West Frontier Province and the banned Tehrik-e-Nifaz-Shariat-e-Mohammadi (TNSM) of the hardline cleric Sufi Mohammad. The accords provided for the enforcement of the Nizam-e-Adl (System of Justice) Regulations in Malakand Division—ostensibly to provide swift and cheap justice at the lower levels—in return for the TNSM prevailing upon the militant Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) of Mullah Fazlullah to lay down their arms. Analysts had pointed out that the TNSM's and TTP's understanding of the Nizam-e-Adl Regulations was critically different from the Government's and that rather than leading to peace, the accords would only strengthen the militants and embolden the Taliban to

spread their ideology to other parts of Pakistan. They also questioned whether the ageing Sufi Mohammad had the kind of influence over his son-in-law Fazlullah and his Taliban fighters as was being claimed or hoped.

Evidence of the correctness of each of these critiques did not take long to materialise. In a public address in Swat after the "peace accord" was endorsed by most of the National Assembly in undue haste and under death threats from the Taliban, Sufi Mohammad claimed that Islamic Shariah law had been put in place in Malakand. Sufi was expected to call for the militants to disarm at his first public address. Instead he ignored that expectation and announced his opposition to democracy and the Pakistani Constitution as "unIslamic". The subsequent infiltration of fighters from Swat into Buner, Shangla and Dir—all districts within Malakand Division—also brought home the fact that they had no inten-